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FAST School of Computing



Safar-e-Nawa

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Safar-e-Nawa



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Author's Declaration

We, Muneeb Lone, Measam Raza, Kabeer Ali, Taha Yasin, Deepak Raj, Hassan Raza, hereby state that our Civics and Community Engagement project titled **"Safar-e-Nawa"** is our own work and it has not been previously submitted by us for taking partial or full credit for the award of any degree at this university or anywhere else in the world. If our statement is found to be incorrect, at any time even after my graduation, the University has the right to revoke my degree.

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We take full responsibility of the work conducted during civics and Community Engagement project titled, “Safar-e-Nawa”. We solemnly declare that the work presented in the project is done solely by me and my group with no significant help from any other person; however, small help wherever taken is duly acknowledged. We have also written the complete report by ourself. Moreover we have not presented this project (or substantially similar work) or any part of the project previously to any other degree awarding institution within Pakistan or abroad.

We understand that the School of Computing of National University Computer and Emerging Sciences has zero tolerance policy towards plagiarism. Therefore we as an author of the above mentioned work solemnly declare that no portion of our report has been plagiarized and any material used in the project from other sources is properly referenced. We further understand that if we are found guilty of any form of plagiarism in my project work even after my graduation, the university reserves the right to revoke my bachelors degree.

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Executive Summary

This report presents an overview of our project for the course Civics and Community Service, undertaken as part of our academic curriculum. Our project aligns with SDG 4: Quality Education and is centered around supporting Mashal Model School, an under-resourced educational institution serving underprivileged children near the Bari Imam area in Islamabad. The aim was to understand the challenges faced by marginalized communities and to contribute towards providing quality education through direct, and meaningful engagement.

The idea for this project arose from a classroom discussion among friends trying to figure out which SDG aligned best with their beliefs. Rather than conceptualize a broad or idealistic solution, we sought a grounded, hands-on approach by collaborating with an existing grassroots organization already making an impact, Red Crescent Pakistan.

The project started off with our group contacting Red Crescent Pakistan, and applying to their Volunteer Program. We first coordinated with our assigned Youth and Volunteer Officer, Sir Tayyab, to outline our objectives and understand the scope of your involvement. We then visited Mashal Model School to assess its conditions, to identify its most pressing needs, and build rapport with the students and staff. Through these interactions, we found that the school urgently required basic educational resources, financial support, and greater visibility, particularly to help guide new students and visitors to its location.

While constrained by project guidelines that prohibited direct fundraising, we shifted our focus to community-based support and awareness-building. We visited crowded public areas in Islamabad to distribute information and raise awareness about Mashal Model School's mission and their needs. We also sourced donated books from vendors at G6's book market,which were later handed over to the school so that they could distribute them as they saw fit.

To address the visibility issue, we commissioned a signboard from a local vendor in i10 with logistical and financial support from Red Crescent Pakistan. In a final hands-on session, we returned to the school and engaged the children in painting and designing the signboard, turning it into both a practical solution and a creative, morale-boosting activity for the students.

Acknowledgements

We, the members of this team, would like to express our sincerest gratitude to all those who contributed to the successful completion of our Civics and Community Service initiative.

First and foremost, we are thankful to our teacher, Ma'am Tahreem Zarar, for her guidance, encouragement, and support throughout the duration of this semester. Her feedback and direction were instrumental in shaping our approach and ensuring the project met its goals.

We extend our heartfelt thanks to Red Crescent Pakistan, particularly Sir Tayyab, for coordinating with us, facilitating our connection with Mashal Model School, and supporting us both logically and financially at key stages of the project.

Our deepest appreciation goes to the staff and students of Mashal Model School, who welcomed us with open arms. Their cooperation, engagement, and resilience made this experience meaningful and memorable.

Lastly, we would also like to acknowledge the vendors who assisted us in sourcing materials and supplies. Their generosity and responsiveness played a crucial role in the execution of our ideas.

Dedication

We dedicate this project to the students of Mashal Model School, whose determination to learn in the face of adversity inspired us every step of the way. Their enthusiasm, creativity, and hope are a powerful reminder of the importance of accessible, quality education for all.

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1. INTRODUCTION TO THE COMMUNITY SERVICE PROJECT

Under Red Crescent Pakistan, this community service project focused on supporting Mashal Model School, a non-formal learning environment near Bari Imam, Islamabad. Children from economically deprived backgrounds attend the school; it lacks continuous funding and teaching resources. Our project aimed to raise the profile of the institution, assist its academic environment, and advocate for the right to education of vulnerable groups.

By listening to both concrete needs and more general community knowledge, the project underlined the part young people-led civic involvement performs in furthering inclusive development and social justice.

1.1. Objectives and Significance of the Project

The core objectives of the project were:

- To identify and address immediate operational and academic needs at Mashal Model School.
- To increase public knowledge of the presence and difficulties of the school within Islamabad.
- To source and provide educational materials, including books, through in-kind donations.
- To promote long-term community participation and underline the need for education in poor communities.

The grassroots impact of this effort reveals its value. Direct connection with local community members, school staff, and children let us create clearly visible, rather tiny changes. The project demonstrated how much student-led projects—even with limited resources and guidelines—can

contribute to increase educational equity. Our work with Red Crescent Pakistan and our interactions with local networks reflect the greater value of civic projects anchored in alliances.

1.2 Needs Assessment

Our needs assessment began with an on-site visit to Mashal Model School, where we observed the learning environment, interacted with teachers and students, and learned about the challenges the school faced. Through these interactions, we discovered several immediate needs:

- A lack of educational materials, such as textbooks for various subjects and age levels.
- Limited visibility, as the school is tucked away with no directional signage to guide visitors or prospective students.
- An absence of sustainable financial support, which affects the school's ability to maintain and grow its services.

Although our project rules limited direct financial contributions, the evaluation let us create workable substitutes—such as commissioning a signboard and collecting books from nearby vendors—to fill up these voids in a sustainable and community-engaged way.

1.3. Alignment of Specific SDGs with Project Goals

This initiative especially matched Sustainable Development Goal 4: Quality Education, namely:

- SDG 4.1, which aims to ensure inclusive and equitable quality primary education for all; and
- SDG 4.A, which focuses on creating effective, safe, and inclusive learning environments.

We directly helped to meet these goals at the community level by providing age-appropriate publications, raising the school's profile, and involving children in artistic endeavors (such as painting their signboard).

As we collaborated closely with local companies, Red Crescent Pakistan, and volunteers, the project also supported SDG 17: Partnerships for the Goals. Our strategy revolved mostly on these alliances, which showed how cross-sector cooperation may increase impact—especially in environments with limited resources.

2. PROJECT DESCRIPTION

2.1. Detail of the Activities Conducted During the Project

The initiative started with an official visit to the Red Crescent Pakistan office, where we met Sir Tayyab, our allocated Youth and Volunteer Officer. This conference helped us to define project goals, explain operational limits of our civic involvement, and get first direction on ethical volunteering methods.

After that, we paid a first visit to Mashal Model School, close to Bari Imam, Islamabad. The visit served to evaluate the state of the institution, acquaint us with the teachers and students, and pinpoint pressing requirements. We saw throughout this visit the dearth of fundamental educational resources, poor infrastructure, and lack of obvious signs guiding individuals toward the school.

The project's guidelines forbade direct funding, but we replied by starting a casual awareness campaign. We toured crowded parts of Islamabad, interacted with local people, and orally shared information on the function and difficulties of the institution. The intention was to raise awareness of the school and maybe encourage public natural support.

Understanding we needed educational materials right away, we went to the G-6 book market in Islamabad and addressed various bookshop owners and suppliers to ask for book contributions fit for elementary school pupils. This outreach produced a good number of books.

After that, Mashal Model School received these books and distributed them among the students with an eye on those in need. Apart from fulfilling a minimum educational need, this deed helped to establish confidence and involvement between our team and the school community.

One important problem influencing visibility was also the absence of a school signboard. In response, we used money made possible by Red Crescent Pakistan to commission a custom

metal sign board from a nearby welder in I-10. To let the kids help to decorate the sign, we also bought paint and painting tools from stores in Aabpara Market.

After delivery, the kids worked on creating the signboard and painting, therefore transforming the project into one run by the community. This endeavor raised student morale, encouraged responsibility, and gave their classroom pride.

We kept open lines of contact with Red Crescent and school personnel throughout the process to make sure each action matched ethical service, inclusiveness, and sustainability.

2.2. Timeline and Resources Used

Project Timeline

- Week 1: Orientation and project briefing with Red Crescent Pakistan; assignment of project scope and team roles.

- Week 2: First visit to Mashal Model School; needs analysis and identification of main difficulties.

- Week 3: Awareness campaign started; community involvement in packed parts of Islamabad.
- Week 4: Visit the G-6 book market to compile donated instructional resources.

- Week 5: Staff and student engagement; book distribution at the institution.

- Week 6: Procurement of a custom sign board from an I-10 welder and paint supplies from Aabpara.

- Week 7: Signboard painting and installation with student involvement.

- Week 8: Final documentation, reflection, and report preparation.

Resources Used

- Human Resources: Project team members; Red Crescent officer (Sir Tayyab); school faculty and students.

- Material Resources: Paint brushes; donated books; sign board materials.

- Financial Resources: Modest funding support from Red Crescent Pakistan

- Community Resources: Support from vendors and bookstore owners in G-6

- Transport: For visits, delivery of materials, and community outreach activities.

3. ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

3.1 Informed Consent and Confidentiality

A basic ethical need for all phases of our investigation was informed consent. We made sure to explicitly communicate the goal of our initiative to the administration, instructors, and students in Mashal Model School in a language and way they could understand. Engagement in any activity—including sign board painting or book distribution—was absolutely voluntary. Following local standards for non-formal learning contexts, verbal permission was sought from school staff members functioning in loco parentis for minors under the age of eighteen.

No names, personal information, or identifiable data of staff or students were recorded, shared, or published in any public-facing materials, presentations, or this report in order to preserve anonymity. If any pictures were taken, they were solely featured with the express permission of the school management. The focus nevertheless stayed on always safeguarding the beneficiaries' dignity and privacy.

3.2 Cultural Sensitivity and Community Integration

Mashal Model School is in a culturally conservative area near Bari Imam, hence we especially strove to follow local customs and guidelines in our behavior, clothes, and language. Team members were taught appropriate behavior covering gender sensitivity, classroom decorum, and community contact etiquette. Plans planned for inclusive events whereby boys and girls were encouraged to participate equally in creative endeavors including book choice and painting.

We also respected religious rites and prayer times, hence our trips and activities did not throw off the calendar or observances of the school. The project stayed mostly cooperative, allowing the school community to guide decisions wherever appropriate.

3.3 Environmental Responsibility and Sustainability

Sustainable choices made with consciousness helped to lessen environmental impact. Rather than entirely new books or supplies, we relied on some donated or second-hand books acquired from local businesses in Islamabad's G-6 market. This not only reduced waste but also encouraged a cyclical use of teaching resources.

Similarly, the paint ingredients were purchased in meager, necessary quantities and the signboard was built from scrap aluminum. Students helped to decorate the board, therefore encouraging creative ownership and reducing the need for outsourcing. The school got all the remaining resources for usage going forward, thus promoting sustainability in the classroom.

3.4 Ethical Standards and Guidelines Followed

Following Red Crescent Pakistan's recommendations for student-led volunteer work, which stress community involvement, non-exploitative methods, and openness, the project further closely followed ethical guidelines provided by our academic supervisors, particularly with regard to consent, representation, and regard for vulnerable groups.

Although this was not a research project needing formal institutional review board (IRB) approval, we nevertheless made sure our actions complied with fundamental ethical guidelines shared by field-based community service projects:

- Do no harm principle.
- Voluntary participation and informed consent.
- Protection of minors and marginalized groups.
- Transparency in intent and communication.

These considerations ensured that our work was socially responsible, respectful, and ethically grounded throughout its execution.

4. OUTCOMES AND IMPACTS

4.1 Project Outcomes

The project yielded several clear and measurable outcomes that aligned with its core objectives. These included:

- Successful distribution of books to students at Mashal Model School, addressing the academic need.

- Design and installation of a school signboard, improving accessibility and making it easier for new students, volunteers, and donors to find the school.

- Community awareness outreach conducted in busy areas of Islamabad, which increased public understanding of the school's role and its challenges.

- Active participation of students in the creation and decoration of the school signboard, fostering a sense of ownership, pride, and engagement.

These outcomes reflect both the hands-on engagement of our team and the practical solutions implemented despite logistical and financial constraints.

4.2 Contribution to Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

The project made a meaningful contribution to SDG 4: Quality Education by directly improving the learning environment at Mashal Model School. This was achieved through:

- Provision of essential learning materials, which supports SDG target 4.1 (universal primary education).

- Improvement of school infrastructure (through signage and student engagement), aligned with SDG target 4.A (inclusive and safe learning spaces).

The project also fulfilled SDG 17: Partnerships for the Goals by building cooperative links between young volunteers, a humanitarian organization, local companies, and academic institutions.

Though the project was modest, its concept, execution, and outcomes reflected more general ideas of inclusive development, educational equity, and community empowerment, therefore helping to contribute to the worldwide SDG framework.

4.3 Direct and Indirect Impacts

Direct impacts of the project included:

- Improved learning resources for children at Mashal Model School through the donation of books.

- More school visibility will probably help to boost student retention and community outreach.

- Boosted student morale and participation through interactive and creative activities like signboard painting.

Indirect impacts included:

- Raised awareness among Islamabad residents about the existence and importance of non-formal educational institutions like Mashal Model School.

- Encouragement of future civic engagement, as the project served as a model for how small, ethical, and low-cost interventions can make a difference.

- Potential increase in volunteer and donor interest, given the improved visibility and credibility of the school following the project.

Though limited in scope, these impacts enable a greater positive change in community attitudes toward education in poor areas, therefore paving the ground for future advocacy, resource mobilization, and policy support.

5. DISCUSSION

5.1 Group Experiences, Skills, and Insights Gained

Participating in this community service project was a significant and transforming experience for our group. Working with Mashal Model School and Red Crescent Pakistan allowed us to personally engage a community in need, therefore surpassing just intellectual knowledge. From preparation and outreach to implementation, we raised interpersonal as well as professional skills at all levels.

We learned how to properly engage across all socioeconomic and educational backgrounds, thus we changed our strategy to be inclusive, polite, and direct. Our achievement largely came from team effort; roles, schedule coordination, and group problem-solving activities enabled us to value responsibility, empathy, and teamwork.

Our experience also reinforced the importance of grassroots activity—how tiny, community-centered efforts may have huge, long-lasting influence. Many of us were moved by the resiliency of the Mashal Model School staff and students, which also sharpened our awareness of educational inequality and our own social responsibility commitment.

We also picked up useful knowledge in:

- Project management and logistics coordination
- Community engagement and ethical communication
- Creative problem-solving under resource constraints
- Building partnerships (with NGOs and local vendors)

The project helped us recognize that sustainable development and civic responsibility are interconnected, and that even modest contributions can become stepping stones for broader change.

5.2 Challenges Encountered and How They Were Addressed

The project came with certain challenges. One of the biggest obstacles turned out to be locating an NGO that would interact with us in a meaningful and relevant way. Many businesses either responded poorly or had criteria incompatible with the extent and duration of our endeavor. After hard work, we managed to establish a cooperative relationship with Red Crescent Pakistan, which proved absolutely essential for the viability of our initiative.

Another major obstacle was the prohibition of direct cash donations, therefore limiting our ability to provide the kind of support Mashal Model School most needed. To assist with this, we resorted to in-kind contributions; we sourced used books from surrounding companies and included local people through unofficial awareness efforts.

Coordinating schedules was another challenge—balancing site visits and group meetings with academic responsibilities required for careful time management and flexibility. We were able to ensure fair involvement among all members and divide tasks by means of open communication and a shared online calendar.

Logistically, we also encountered difficulties finding a reliable signboard producer and delays in material procurement. Tenacity and local contacts—including Red Crescent staff recommendations for suppliers—helmed in to settle these.

Underlining the need for creativity, patience, and cultural sensitivity in community service initiatives, these challenges finally enhanced our adaptability and teamwork even if they at times were challenging.

6. RECOMMENDATIONS

6.1 Recommendations for Future Student Projects

Learning from our experiences and the difficulties we negotiated, we provide the following advice to students organizing comparable community service projects:

1. Begin Outreach Early

   Begin contacting neighborhood groups and NGOs much in advance. Finding the ideal partner can take awhile, hence extra time for coordination is rather important.

2. Design Flexible, Resource-Efficient Plans

   Starting with financial restrictions, assume a need for in-kind support, skill-based contributions, or awareness campaigns requiring little money but great participation rather than depending just on cash-based solutions.

3. Establish Clear Team Roles

   Early division of tasks should be followed routinely. Well defined roles, deadlines, and responsibility help to lower burnout and increase effectiveness.

4. Document Everything

   Track contacts, plans, permissions, and visits meticulously. By building a reusable knowledge base, this not only aids in reporting but also benefits upcoming groups.

5. Engage with the Community Respectfully

   Consider local sensitivities, communication techniques, and cultural standards. Community service is about learning as much as it is about serving others; approach every contact with humility.

6.2 Recommendations for NGOs and Partner Organizations

For organizations like Red Crescent Pakistan or educational institutions like Mashal Model School, the following suggestions would help to increase the effect and durability of student projects:

1. Streamline Communication Channels

   Set aside a particular liaison officer for student organizations. This lessens uncertainty, speeds up coordination, and fosters confidence on both sides.

2. Create Brief, Structured Project Guidelines

   One-page briefings on how student initiatives may help the organization—what is authorized, what is needed, contact protocol—would help to streamline goal-oriented and efficient partnerships.

3. Encourage Small-Scale, High-Impact Initiatives

   Many student teams run under time and financial restrictions. NGOs should help them toward targeted activities—such as awareness campaigns, infrastructure upgrades, or teaching seminars—that call for little money but provide obvious results.

4. Provide Basic Logistical Support

   Project effectiveness can be greatly raised even with small help—that is, by allowing school resources to be used or by helping to discover trustworthy vendors.

5. Promote Long-Term Continuity

   Record former student initiatives and propose follow-up events. By building on past work instead of beginning from scratch, future student groups can increase the long-term effects of their efforts.

7. CONCLUSION

Working together with Mashal Model School, a non-formal school near Bari Imam, Islamabad, this project aimed to fix the educational problems that poor areas were having, as explained in the Executive Summary. Our team worked with Red Crescent Pakistan to put on a number of powerful, community-driven events that raised awareness of the school, provided much-needed learning materials, and raised awareness among the public about how important it is to have easy access to education.

We overcame many problems by coming up with creative solutions and working together as a team. Some of the problems we faced were limited financial donations, problems with logistics, and initially having trouble finding a good NGO partner. Planning and making a school signboard and sorting book donations are just a few of the things we do that show we care about SDG 4's values of Quality Education and Civic Participation.

The project helped the school and its students right away and taught them a lot about ethics, teamwork, and being sensitive to other cultures. What was more important was that it showed how small, well-run projects could help with bigger social goals.

By detailing all of our efforts, the outcomes, and the lessons learned, this report gives other student groups a foundation on which to build and improve community service activities in similar settings.